

Ever been talking about something important with someone you care about and found it frustrating instead of fruitful? Negative energy can then cast a 26 over your efforts to build a shared understanding.

In fact collaborative problem-solving conversations require skills. Strong listening skills are essential. Sprinkling in positivity via appreciation, 27 smiles, and warm comments helps. So does the essential ability to keep your emotional tone in the calm zone. If the tone of a dialogue heats up and anger erupts, the dialogue 28 from collaborative to adversarial, and progress is likely to come to an immediate 29.

In addition, effective dialogue generally has another important characteristic: symmetry.

Symmetry in dialogue refers to the balance of how much each partner talks. Are you each getting equal airtime? When one participant does most of the talking, this asymmetry or lack of balance tends to become annoying to one or both of you. The silent partner 30 tires of only listening, while the talker can feel 31. Usually, both would prefer more equal give and take.

Different rates of speech and levels of voice volume can 32 symmetry as well. The faster or louder partner can easily begin taking up more airtime. The slower-talking or softer-voiced one can have trouble getting the floor.

Conversations also lose balance when one partner's opinions count more than the other's. One person's input may carry more sway because their style of expression is more 33. One viewpoint may tend to get lost because it is expressed more 34.

If either partner fairly consistently 35 or evaporates, modifying the pattern will be helpful. The dialogue will feel more productive, and at the same time, the relationship overall is likely to feel more positive.

- A) affectionate
- B) approximately
- C) elapses
- D) erode
- E) flattered
- F) flips
- G) halt
- H) overburdened

- I) predominates
- J) propagate
- K) scenario
- L) shadow
- M) tentatively
- N) typically
- O) vigorous